

QUEEN OF HEARTS
Vasundhara Raje greets the people during her birthday celebrations in Salasar

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prayer sessions. People in Rajasthan see in Raje an old-style Hindu devotee, which they feel separates her from the hardcore Hindutva her party tries to practise. And her Gwalior royalty sheen, expectedly, does her no harm either. Although she played down the numbers, 55 sitting BJP MLAs and 12 MPs and 118 ex-MLAs and ministers greeted her in person during the celebrations that went on till 10 pm on March 4. In contrast, the Poonia-organised protests had just seven MPs and 22 MLAs attending, with even some known Raje critics hot-footing it to Salasar later to greet her.

The next day (March 5) saw another major event that showcased Raje's clout. The ex-CM could not make it to the Jat Maha Kumbh in Jaipur but her son and MP Dushyant Singh was one of the major stars present. He was introduced to the gathering as a "Jat maharaja" as he is from Dholpur, the prominent Jat dynasty in Rajasthan into which Raje, a Scindia by birth, is married. Dushyant is also married into a Gujjar family, which is how Raje is often able to canvass votes without caste biases (especially of Jats who mostly vote on caste lines). The event also had a smattering of leaders from both the Congress and the BJP, but it was clear where the organisers' loyalties lay. Indeed, even in the past, the mahasabha had indicated that they were partial towards Raje. This was also one of the reasons why her rally at Salasar, in the heart of the Jat-Rajput Shekhawati region, was a big success despite two prominent leaders of the area, deputy leader of the opposition, Rajendra Rathore, and Poonia, staying away.

NEARLY A MONTH HAS GONE BY AND THE BJP HIGH COMMAND IS STILL UNDECIDED ON WHO WILL TAKE GULAB KATARIA'S PLACE AS LEADER OF THE OPPOSITION

The question that everyone is now asking is: has the BJP high command worked out a strategy for Rajasthan? Nearly a month has gone by and it has still not decided on who will replace Gulab Chand Kataria—who has moved out as Assam governor—as leader of the opposition. Some sources say the party is planning a cabinet reshuffle that will include leaders from Rajasthan, and things will become clearer after.

The BJP knows well Raje is the only leader capable of turning the anti-incumbency votes against Gehlot to the party's advantage. Her record in the massive victories of 2003 and 2013 speak for themselves. Poonia has worked hard in the state, along with organisational general secretary Chandrashekhar, but he has failed to inspire the cadre. Under his stewardship, the BJP has also lost seven of the past eight byelections in the state.

Meanwhile, Raje is playing her cards well. Despite the high command's apprehensions, Raje had Prime Minister Narendra Modi's face displayed prominently on her birthday event posters. On the dais, too, there were huge cutouts of her along with those of the PM, Union home minister Amit Shah, BJP president J.P. Nadda and even Poonia. Clearly, she is covering all the bases in a bid to become the sole choice on who will lead the party in the assembly election at the end of the year. Unlike last time, there are no party cadres actually sloganeering against her. But will the high command shed its ambivalence? ■